DPM LEARNING HUB

12-Week Study Plan

From spreadsheets to dashboards to automations · about 4–6 hours a week

This plan turns the hub into a guided, twelve-week course — about **4–6 hours a week**. Each week lists what to study, what to practise in the in-browser runners, and a checkpoint to tick off. The order matters: each tool builds on the one before, so resist jumping ahead.

☐ a task to complete ✓ checkpoint = prove you can do it ■ milestone = a graded exam ≥ 80%

The path at a glance

1 Foundations	2 Excel	3 SQL	4 Power BI	5 Power Automate	★ Capstone
Wk 1	Wk 2–4	Wk 5–8	Wk 9–10	Wk 11	Wk 12

How they fit together: the same idea recurs in every tool — summarise a measure by a dimension. Excel's `SUMIFS` ≈ SQL's `GROUP BY` ≈ Power BI's `CALCULATE`. A PivotTable is OLAP on your desktop, and the star schema you learn in Foundations powers both your SQL joins and your Power BI model.

MONTH 1 · FOUNDATIONS & EXCEL

Week 1 · Data foundations ~4

- ☐ Read the **Foundations** page end to end: tables & keys, how rows are stored, ER & EER diagrams, star vs snowflake and OLAP.
- ☐ Do all the self-check quizzes. Be able to explain a star schema and the five OLAP operations (slice, dice, drill down, up, pivot).
- ☐ Skim the Excel cheat sheet so you know what's coming.

✓ Checkpoint: you can explain primary vs foreign keys and what OLAP slice / dice / drill mean.

Week 2 · Excel — Basics ~5

- ☐ Excel track, **Basic** tier: SUM / AVERAGE / COUNT, cell references and the $ lock, IF and IFERROR.
- ☐ Download the sample workbook and follow along; use the **formula runner** for every *Try it*.
- ☐ Keep the Excel cheat sheet open as you work.

✓ Checkpoint: rebuild three Basic worked examples from scratch in your own sheet.

Week 3 · Excel — Intermediate ~5

- ☐ **Intermediate** tier: SUMIFS & COUNTIFS, XLOOKUP and INDEX/MATCH, the key text and date functions.
- ☐ Practise writing criteria (">100", wildcards, cell references) until they're automatic.

✓ Checkpoint: answer five "by region / by status" questions using SUMIFS and COUNTIFS.

Week 4 · Excel — Advanced + PivotTables ~6

- [ ] **Advanced** tier: dynamic arrays (FILTER / UNIQUE / SORT) and LET; plus Power Query basics for repeatable cleaning.
- [ ] Work the **PivotTables** section and map each layout back to OLAP — rows/columns are dimensions, Values is the measure.
- [ ] Sit the **Excel exam**. Retake it until you're comfortable.

■ ***Milestone: Excel exam ≥ 80%.***

MONTH 2 · SQL

Week 5 · SQL — Basics ~5

- [ ] SQL track, **Basic** tier: SELECT / FROM, WHERE, ORDER BY / LIMIT, DISTINCT.
- [ ] Run every example in the **SQL runner** (a real database in your browser) and tweak it to see what changes.

✓ ***Checkpoint: write five queries that filter and sort the orders table.***

Week 6 · SQL — Intermediate ~5

- [ ] Aggregates + GROUP BY, HAVING, and JOINs across the orders and targets tables.
- [ ] Notice the bridge from last month: Excel's SUMIFS is SQL's GROUP BY.

✓ ***Checkpoint: reproduce a PivotTable result (revenue by region) as a GROUP BY query.***

Week 7 · SQL — Advanced ~6

- [ ] CASE for if-then logic, subqueries, CTEs (WITH), and window functions (RANK, running totals).
- [ ] Rewrite a nested subquery as a CTE to feel why CTEs read better.

✓ ***Checkpoint: return the top-N orders per region using a window function.***

Week 8 · Consolidate SQL ~4

- [ ] Redo the trickiest *Try it* tasks without looking. Optionally install SQL Server with the setup guide and load the CSV.
- [ ] Sit the **SQL exam**.

■ ***Milestone: SQL exam ≥ 80%.***

MONTH 3 · POWER BI, POWER AUTOMATE & INTEGRATION

Week 9 · Power BI — model ~5

- [ ] Power BI track, **Basic** & **Intermediate**: Power Query (get & shape), then relationships and the star schema.
- [ ] This is where Foundations pays off — build the model the way week 1 described.

✓ ***Checkpoint: load the sample data and build a clean star-schema model.***

Week 10 · Power BI — DAX & visuals ~6

- [ ] **Advanced** tier: measures vs columns, CALCULATE and filter context, time intelligence; then the chart chooser.
- [ ] Use the **DAX checker** to validate each measure as you write it.
- [ ] Sit the **Power BI exam**.

■ ***Milestone: Power BI exam ≥ 80%.***

Week 11 · Power Automate ~5

- [ ] Power Automate track: triggers and actions, conditions and loops, and expressions; plus the four flow types.
- [ ] Sketch a flow that emails an alert when an order is overdue.
- [ ] Sit the **Power Automate exam**.

■ ***Milestone: Power Automate exam ≥ 80%.***

Week 12 · Capstone — put it together ~6

- [ ] End to end: clean the **messy dataset** in Power Query → model it in Power BI → write three key measures → build a one-page report → design a Power Automate alert around it.
- [ ] Revisit any track whose exam was below 80% and close the gap.

■ ***Milestone: a one-page dashboard plus an automation design, built start to finish.***

Five tips to finish

- [ ] **Consistency beats intensity.** Three or four short sessions a week beat one long cram.
- [ ] **Always try before you reveal.** The struggle on each *Try it* is where the learning sticks.
- [ ] **Keep the cheat sheet for the current tool open** while you practise.
- [ ] **Type, don't read.** Re-run every example in the runner and change something.
- [ ] **Retake the exams.** They're randomised — a score above 80% twice means it's real.

Everything you need is in the hub at **ahmedwalid4499.github.io** — pages, runners, exams and the cheat sheets on the Downloads page.